

ALDWYNEDIT

Welcome to another episode of Travel Radio Australia. In this episode, we catch up with media queen, show business journalist and former Australian youth champion table tennis player Aldwyn Altenay. We chat with Ben Roberts from Queensland Rail about an epic 650km rail journey from Gladstone at the beginning of the Great Barrier Reef south to Brisbane and about all the other great trains available in the huge state of Queensland.

We meet with one of the legendary stuntmen of Australia who has appeared in a number of Hollywood movies including The Matrix, Star Wars and many others, Dar Davies. We talk to one of Australia's premier show business authors and vaudeville expert, Jax Minnelli. The Australian media scene is vibrant and one of the premier journalists and media experts in the country is Aldwyn Altenay.

I caught up with her in Southport in Queensland. Travel Radio Australia, we are on the Gold Coast in Queensland in Southport and we're with the fabulous and famous Aldwyn Altenay. And Aldwyn, welcome to the program.

Thank you, Geoff. Great to be here. Now, Aldwyn, you have a tremendous media background in Australia.

Tell us about a bit of how you got started and how it all happened for you. Thank you. Yes, 41 years media experience.

I am 51 now. I was first interviewed by the Manly Daily at 10 years of age in Sydney for table tennis. And I had a fascination with the media from that point.

I remember the photographer and journalist coming out to our place in North Bow Gala when I was 10 and the photographer got up on a ladder and was taking photos of me with the old film photography back then. And I remember looking up at this photographer up on the ladder thinking, wow, that looks like such a cool thing to do. I'd love to do something like that one day.

That's when my fascination developed. And then at 11 years of age, I was on Cartoon Connection on Channel 7. I remember being in the studio in Sydney looking at this massive camera in front of my face and the reporter turned to me and trying to relax me before the show. She said, now just don't think of the 2 million people watching this right now.

I remember looking at that camera. All I could think about was the 2 million people watching this right now. And I froze.

It was the worst interview ever. However, they did have a table tennis table in the studio and my brother and I got on and we were just playing forehand to forehand, just warming up. And that's it because you were a team champion at table tennis for Australia, weren't you? Yes.

I was a top junior table tennis player back then in the under 17 division and the under 15 division. And I ended up representing Australia for six years. And then I went on and I did a radio show at age 13 at Radio Manly Warringah.

I went on and did a media degree at Canberra University and I majored in photojournalism and TV production. Then went on for 20 years. I worked in TV, radio, print in the media.

And now I've had my own media business as well on the Gold Coast for 20 years. So it's been quite a ride. And I've interviewed some phenomenal people in that time and had some amazing adventures.

Well, I was one of the people that you interviewed, what, 25 years ago when we first met, when I first started off really as a professional magician here on the Gold Coast. And the Gold Coast is a great place for entertainment. And you were right in the thick of it with the Gold Coast Bulletin.

You were show business reporter for the Gold Coast. And the amount of incredibly famous people you have interviewed in the past. Tell us a bit about that.

Yes. Thank you, Geoff. Well, in 2000, I actually got a job as a sub editor at the Bulletin.

And then I went over to the Sun and I was the entertainment reporter there for five years. And how I met you is your mum, Betty, beautiful Betty. She said, you have to meet my son.

And sure enough, I met and she told me, you're an amazing media person and magician, et cetera. And we did multiple stories back then. And I loved your work.

And we've just got along famously ever since, which has been really cool. I've also had the great fortune to interview people like Hugh Jackman, Russell Crowe, Cindy Lauper, Debbie Harry from Blondie. And then later on after that, I interviewed Charlie Sheen and Jewel in LA at a big conference as well.

So I've interviewed some amazing people. And Hugh Jackman, I interviewed him in person back then when he did Paperback Hero with Claudia Carvin. And we did that in Brisbane.

And he was a lovely guy back then and well before the Wolverine days and The Greatest Showman, one of my favourite all-time movies. I've seen it three times and we actually reviewed it on Movie Review TV, which is one of my shows that I've now got online. I now do a lot of online media, social media, got several online TV shows and podcasts that I do.

What I love about all these famous people that I've interviewed is that they love what they do. They're really passionate about what they do. Most of them are really down to earth, really decent people.

And you can tell that they love their lives. And they've also toughened themselves to criticism,

which is where we could learn a lot from a lot of celebrities that we still see around the place nowadays. Now a lot have come and gone because a lot of them haven't handled the criticism so well.

But the fact is the more you put yourself out there, the more you step up and speak up, the more you're going to have your lovers and you're going to have your haters out there. And the biggest thing that I teach people and my clients with my Mass Media Mastery program with my media business is I always say to people, you know, your X factor is your story. What is it that you love to do? You know, life is so short.

You think a third of people die by the age of 65. What is it you love to do and how can you do more of that? And how can you monetize that so that when you love what you do, you never have to work another day in your life? And they're the kind of people I love hanging out with now, people that are on purpose, on mission. And when the why is big enough, the how will show up about how to do things.

So don't stress about the how, just enjoy your life. Notice what lights you up and do more of that. I'm very impressed with a great young artist called Youngblood.

And I don't know whether you've seen Youngblood, but he is just so huge in all over the world now. And one of the greatest things he does is he treats his fans like gold. He really, really appreciates being with his fans.

Nothing is too much for him to do with his fans. And that's what I really appreciate. And he's a mix of Sid Vicious, Elvis Presley, a rap star, a singer.

He does practically everything. And that's Y-U-N-G-B-L-U-D. And when you see the way he interacts with his fans, that's very important, isn't it? Because a lot of people who are famous can sort of lose that and think, oh, I'm so famous, I don't want to connect with my fans anymore.

And that's a downhill spiral. The fact is all celebrities go to the bathroom, all of them would have showers at some stage, all of them eat food, but they are other human beings. And just because they're famous doesn't make them any better or worse than anyone else.

And yes, for some people, the fame definitely goes to their head and some of them become very arrogant and egotistical, but they're the ones often that we have a disconnect with. The ones that we really warm to, the celebrities that we love are the ones that do share authentically, that do share from the heart and that we can relate to. And yes, if they treat you well, obviously that's great because the more that we know that people care about us, the more that we like them as well.

So I think that care factor is really, really important. And to always be at a place where you're being of service, always look at how you can be of service. They say there's no greater purpose

than being of service.

And the more that we love what we're doing and we work in alignment with that, the more we are being of service because there are hints in what you do every day and what you love as to what your purpose is here on the planet. Travel news, features and interviews from around the world. This is Travel Radio Australia with your host, Jeff Harrison.

And I do believe everything happens for us, not to us. So it's also looking at all the experiences we have in our life, all the ups and downs of the rollercoaster ride of life and looking at where we can learn on that journey and how we can stay in an elevated state as much as possible and look for the things that we can appreciate, look for the gratitude in what we do, as opposed to looking at things we can whinge about. And that's the thing about the media.

We've been so conditioned to live in fear and live in drama from the way the mass media works. And if you see an amazing documentary called Out of Shadows that was done by two Hollywood stunt guys, it talks about how we've been conditioned and brainwashed by the education system and by the media to live in fear. And this is how a lot of people are controlled or feel controlled by the government, by the mass media, et cetera.

And the more that we come into alignment with what really lights us up with our own joy, the more that we will rise above that. And we'll have more freedom in our life when we realize we don't have to be controlled by someone else. We don't have to seek permission from others to do whatever we want to do in life.

Anything is possible. And too many people out there live lives that they don't love. People in the nine to five jobs that can't wait for Friday and they dread Monday.

And so they're living three quarters of their life in misery. Is that really how you want to live your life? When you think a third of people die by 65 and 90% of people die with regrets. And I must say, I'm very grateful that I work in the media and I love the media and I've embraced the changing face of media too.

We're at a point now where we have about 5 billion of the world's population of active social media users. Now, Facebook only started in 2004. And so if we're not embracing and growing with the changes in our industry, also we're going to get left behind.

If I was still doing film photography and I didn't embrace digital photography, I would definitely get left behind. And this is where a lot of photographers went out of business, they didn't embrace the changes in technology. Now, of course, we have AI.

And so now while there's all this fake media out there, we don't know what's a real photo or what's a real video anymore with AI. It's even more important to connect from the heart, to connect authentically with people when we're putting ourselves out there and share our

experiences, because that's something that robots will never have, is they will never have a heart. So sharing heart to heart is so important.

The internet has evened everything out, right? In the past, a normal person without access to a broadcasting license or whatever, the mass media was for the elites, basically. But now people can actually make their own media, distribute their own media very, very cheaply. You've got incredible platforms like Instagram, TikTok, all this sort of thing where people can actually get their own stories out there, which is a huge paradigm shift.

Yes, we have seen massive changes with the face of media in that respect too. Now people are their own media. In 2018, we only had 500,000 podcasts.

Now, 2025, we have 6.5 million podcasts, but most of those, there's not more than 10 episodes out there. So that's saying a lot for those that are consistent and persistent with their message and what they do. They're the ones that are going to really stand out.

And that's something about you, Jeff. You've been in the media all these years as well. It's extraordinary the things you've done.

And yeah, it's absolutely leveled the playing field now that people can create their own media and people follow people. We want to hear from people. This is where all the influences have come out.

We're following the influences, the people that we gel with, that we like, we're following those people and the people that are brave enough to speak their truth about whatever's going on in the world. And I always believe it's important to be kind when you are putting messages out in the mass media. There's no need to be nasty just because someone has a different opinion to you.

There's no need to be nasty to those people. And we saw this through the whole, you know, COVID pandemic. We saw a lot of nastiness, a lot of cyber bullying, and this is where you have to toughen yourself to criticism.

People can consult you to help them to do these things with the Mass Media Mastery Program. And you also have the things like the Good News Program, which is great because that's all good news, right? Tell us a bit about that. Yes, I actually started a Good News Day on the 8th of the 8th, 2018.

And that was actually after four of my friends suicided. It was actually after the fourth friend suicided. And I've personally had depression.

And having worked in the media where it was 99% negative, it impacted my mental health over the years. It was a very stressful environment to work in as a mainstream media reporter, as you would know. It's go, go, go, deadline, deadline, deadline.

This is where a lot of journalists were drinking and smoking and doing whatever they could to deal with, you know, the increasing pressures of the industry back in the day. And, you know, after that happened, I thought, well, I want to see more good news in the world. And I started a Good News Day, which was an annual day.

The reason I did the 8th of the 8th is because on August 8th is actually the day that my niece has her birthday, and she was actually turning 10th on the 8th of the 8th. So I picked that day, August 8th, and it was soon after my fourth friend suicided. So the whole idea was to encourage people to share some good news on that day.

And then during COVID in June 2020, I ramped it up and launched the Global Good News Challenge. And that's where every month, it's a free challenge, and I encourage people to share gratitude and good news. Because no matter what is going on in the world, and particularly things we can't control, like the lockdowns that we saw over, you know, the pandemic, we saw a lot of craziness in that time.

A lot of that you cannot control, but you can control how you're going to be about that. And the more we can come to gratitude around anything, it just shifts our whole energy. You're able to attract a lot more amazing stuff into your life when you get into gratitude.

And when you share good news, it also makes you feel amazing. And everyone who sees your live videos feels amazing as well. So all the details on that are pinned to the top of the Global Good News Challenge Facebook page.

And one more thing we should talk about is your Animal Action Day. And animal action has taken off in Australia. Tell us a bit about that.

Yeah, thank you, Jeff. Well, that's something I started in 2007. Basically, I was sick of seeing all the animal cruelty out there.

I saw a documentary called Earthlings, which showed how we've treated animals over time, how we've used them for food, clothing, scientific research. And I wanted to encourage people to take action for animals. The whole area of animal cruelty felt like such a massive thing.

I thought, what can I do to impact animal cruelty? I thought, if I just put a day on, encourage everyone to take some action, then we'll make a bigger difference out there. And that's where Animal Action Day was born, the world's first Animal Action Day. It was all about awareness, appreciation, respect for animals.

And we did seven free day events. We had 30 performers and speakers at our first event. It was a free event for the first seven years.

Then we did some paid events, and we did some sit-down dinner events. And every year we

focused on a different animal charity. We did fundraisers for elephants, for orangutans, for dogs, for wildlife, for big cats.

We did some extraordinary events. We've now done 18 annual events of animal action events. Last year, we did one for the bees.

How can people find out more about you online, Aldwyn? Aldwyn Altenay, the media queen, we call you. Yes. Well, you can Google me.

You'll find heaps online. But the best place to go really is Linktree forward slash Aldwyn. That's L-I-N-K-T-R dot E-E forward slash Aldwyn, spelled A-L-D-W-Y-N.

That has all my links there. And if you just search my name, you'll see me all over socials. And that link you'll find in my bio on most social media.

Aldwyn Altenay, media queen, and thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia. Thank you, Geoff. It's been an absolute pleasure.